



iQOO Neo 6 launched in India

The phone is equipped with the Snapdragon 870, SoC, triple rear cameras and upto 12GB of RAM. <https://dgit.in/jun22-52>



Jio launches a game controller

Priced at ₹3,499, the controller comes with Bluetooth support and upto 8 hours of battery life. <https://dgit.in/jun22-53>

into the form we see it in today. They decided to use helium-neon lasers which were way more affordable than the 500-watt bulbs and also wasted less amount of energy along with generating less heat. Barcodes were also codes that could only be read in one direction. However, with the use of lasers with motorised moving mirrors, barcodes could then be scanned from multiple directions while also having the capability to read partially damaged labels.

IBM'S UPC BARCODE

There were only two competitors in the barcodes race, RCA and IBM. Even though RCA had bought the original patent of the barcode, IBM had the next thing to a treasure map, the man who made the map. IBM had hired Norman Woodland to help them work out a standard that would be easier to read and less prone to errors.

IBM was able to develop what we now call the linear UPC barcode which was easily able to beat the Bullseye design in the first registered patent. The reason? The limitations of the printers of the time. At times, the print would smear in the direction of printing while printing a bullseye code whereas the UPC codes would come out looking flawless since they were nothing but vertical lines of different widths.

The interesting thing about the UPC barcodes is that it holds only two little pieces of information, at least for things that are sold to end users – the manufacturer, and the product code.

If you were to pick up 10 packets of chips in a supermarket, they would all have the same UPC number as products like these do not need a separate serial number. They simply have a batch number to track faults in their bulk production batches which, if found, allows them to issue a full recall.

The UPC code can only encode up to 11 digits(0-9) along with a 12th which is called a checksum. The

checksum is the result of a function or an algorithm that may have been applied to the rest of the numbers. Its main purpose is to ensure accuracy in the scanning of products and other things that hold a barcode.

HEADED FOR THE STORE!

The lowering costs of lasers, rise in usage of integrated circuitry, and of course, the invention of the UPC barcode led us to this moment. On June 26, 1974, at 8:01 am, Sharon Buchanan scanned the first grocery item ever in a Marsh's Supermarket in Troy, Ohio – a 10-pack of Wrigley's Juicy Fruit gum. The pack of gum along with the receipt are now in the Smithsonian Museum where they rest as the parts of history.

Once they became the norm, barcodes were printed on every new product being released to markets. These were aimed at end users who were slowly and steadily getting used to the technology that now dominated the world and yet goes unnoticed.

Today, millions and billions of barcodes get scanned daily in various different applications – supermarket billing, logistics tracking, and even in hospitals to store patient details.

A WEIRD PHASE IN THE HISTORY OF BARCODES

A history of barcodes would be incomplete without the mention of one of the weirdest inventions made for it. The :CueCat! Yep, that is exactly how it is spelt and we did not make an error while typing or printing even though every software we type this in thinks it is a glaring error.

Now, how did the :CueCat even become a gadget that people might need? You see, back in the 2000s, many renowned publications in the US started to print proprietary barcodes next to the articles or advertisements they would publish. Their purpose? Well, if the user wanted to learn more about the article or the advertisement, they could scan the code which would lead them to a webpage that would, in fact, let

them learn more! Here's the problem though, smartphones weren't a thing yet, so how would we, the readers, scan the codes? Easy solution, use a :CueCat! Easy to say, but here's the thing, nobody wanted to pay \$10 for a proprietary scanner that could only be used to scan proprietary barcodes. The lack of hits on those web pages, along with the low sales of the :CueCat was seeming to be a failure when RadioShack came along and gave the subscribers of the aforementioned magazines a free :CueCat in the hopes that once people got hooked on the process, they would buy more :CueCats because they



A :CueCat, one of the weirdest, yet cutest tech inventions ever

wanted to learn more about the things mentioned in the magazine. They even gave away thousands of Cuecats(Yes we missed the colon, it was tiring okay? And not to mention weird) in their physical stores to users encouraging them to use the darn thing. But to no avail.

In the end, the :CueCat ended up as yet another useless gadget that actually had a clever marketing strategy. I mean, a cat next to a mouse on my desk? You can have my money.

Here's a fun activity you can do right now – Look around, and count the number of things that still hold a barcode in your room and if there are not many of them, think about everything that you've ever bought that had a barcode on its packaging when you checked out with it. This will make you realise just how far we have come in terms of evolution in barcode technology! 